

Inspection of Luton local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 19 to 30 January 2026

Lead inspector: Rebecca Dubbins, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Requires improvement to be good
Overall effectiveness	Good

Services for children in Luton have improved since the last inspection in 2022, when the overall effectiveness was 'requires improvement to be good'. Luton was announced as a Families First for Children (FFC) pathfinder in April 2024, and since then, leaders have reconfigured services into locality-based family help services which have resulted in improved, seamless and timely support for children and their families who require help and protection. This organisational change has been devised and managed well, with leaders working effectively with partners to provide a continuity of service for children and their families throughout the transition.

Leaders have a thorough understanding of the quality and impact of their services on families, and as a result, with significant work undertaken, services for children in care and care leavers have improved. While there is more to do to improve the services for care leavers to ensure they receive a consistently good service, much of this is under way, but it is too soon yet to see the full impact.

Luton is a culturally diverse area with high levels of deprivation. Diverse staff working in children's services represent the communities they serve and support them to maximise the opportunities to help children achieve. Leaders have provided a positive working culture and have worked diligently to attract and retain staff. As a

result, more stability has been created, meaning that children and their families have culturally informed, consistent workers, whom they can relate to.

What needs to improve?¹

- The quality of plans and the oversight of children subject to supervision orders. (outcome 3, national framework)
- Consistency in the timely approval and support of kinship carers. (outcome 2, national framework)
- The quality and consistency of support and pathway planning for care leavers. (outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and their families receive the right help at the right time. As a pathfinder for FFC, leaders, in conjunction with their partners, have developed a wide range of prevention and early intervention services that meet the needs of children and their families effectively. Luton's multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH) and family help service have been designed to ensure that if the needs of children and families do escalate, they experience a continuity of service to help them make necessary changes. Children and families benefit from consistent workers, which helps build trusting relationships.
2. Children referred to the MASH receive a timely and appropriate response. Workers and managers consult with a variety of partner agencies located in the MASH to ensure information is shared and families are consulted about the support they would like. A multi-agency team (MAT) is available to support families who have emerging needs. When there is concern for children's welfare, this is identified by skilled and professionally curious workers and action is taken swiftly to respond to and reduce the risks posed to children. When there are concerns for children out of hours, the emergency duty team respond appropriately, promptly act when needed, and work with their colleagues in the MASH to ensure this is followed up the next day. As a result, children and families get the help they need regardless of the time of day.
3. Workers in the family help service understand the help and support children and their families need. This is based on thorough assessments, which are timely and completed to a high standard. Assessments fully consider children's circumstances, their holistic needs and their family's history. Workers draw on the expertise of partners in the MAT who work alongside them with parents and

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

carers in accordance with plans that are devised to provide the necessary support.

4. If concerns for children escalate, or if children are at immediate risk, workers identify this and consult promptly with their managers and lead child protection practitioners (LCPPs). LCPPs or team managers will convene and chair strategy discussions that include a wide range of relevant partners to understand risks to children and how these can be mitigated. Information is shared well by partners in these meetings, which focus on the child and their lived experience, with workers appropriately applying cultural competence. Decisions made in strategy discussions are therefore informed and proportionate and result appropriately in a support plan or a child protection enquiry. Safety planning is implemented effectively to ensure that children are safe while such enquiries are ongoing. The family help model ensures that children and their families receive the consistency of support from known workers even when risks escalate and social workers are allocated to conduct child protection enquiries.
5. Child protection enquiries are comprehensive, stipulate the needs of children and their families and articulate risks well. Informed chronologies help practitioners to understand patterns of behaviour, and cultural genograms capture family relationships, matters impacting parental capacity and intergenerational trauma. Children's records outline both protective factors and worries and show appropriate consideration about what will help families to make the changes necessary.
6. When children are considered to be at risk of significant harm, child protection conferences are convened promptly and include relevant partners who share information effectively. These meetings are focused on the risks to children and how these risks can be reduced. The creation of LCPPs who oversee the child protection planning process has supported appropriate action to ensure that children and families receive a supportive and timely response. This oversight and scrutiny have helped to support positive outcomes for children.
7. Children's plans are mostly reviewed regularly in child in need, core group meetings and review child protection conferences. Plans mostly set out the actions that are needed for children's circumstances to change for the better, with clear contingency plans in place. For parents, this helps them to know how to make the changes necessary, and what actions will be taken if children's circumstances do not change. For a small number of children who have experienced neglect, the written plans do not always address the impact of cumulative harm and do not focus sufficiently on the lived experience of the child. The balance of a proportionate and supportive response versus the impact of ongoing harm on children is not always captured appropriately in assessments and in management oversight. As a result, decisive action is not always taken when needed.
8. Children subject to supervision orders and their families do not always receive timely and effective support to meet their needs. These children are supported

via child in need planning processes; however, review meetings do not always take place on time, children's plans do not sufficiently outline risk and the support outlined in children's plans is not always provided. This means that the social work intervention in these children's lives is not always positively impacting changes for children. When this was raised with leaders during the inspection, they acknowledged this and have put plans in place to oversee this cohort of children more closely.

9. Family network meetings are an integral part of the work with families, with the wider support network being considered early on. Families are actively encouraged to get involved to support children and their parents, with practical and financial support provided from a bespoke 'family network support packages fund'. This has enabled many children to remain living with their families and for their circumstances to improve.
10. Children are visited regularly by their workers, who use a range of tools to complete direct work. The quality of this direct work varies. In stronger examples, purposeful direct work demonstrates sensitive conversations that address complex matters and are aligned to actions within the child's plan. This helps children and their families to understand the progress made.
11. Pre-proceedings work as part of the Public Law Outline is effective. Families benefit from purposeful, proportionate interventions with effective progression to divert from court proceedings where appropriate. When court applications are necessary, the quality of the work undertaken in pre-proceedings supports timely progression to conclude safe care arrangements for children. Letters before proceedings are issued promptly to parents and mostly clearly explain what changes need to be made.
12. Disabled children receive appropriate support to meet their needs. Families benefit from coordinated support, including education and specialist interventions. For some children, this has resulted in improved routines, strengthened family relationships and reduced risks of family breakdown.
13. When children aged 16 to 17 present as homeless, they receive an appropriate response, with a joint assessment undertaken with colleagues from housing services. Children are offered an advocate and made aware of their rights, including their rights to be accommodated. Most children are supported to safely remain at home with their families.
14. Children living in private fostering arrangements are well supported. The assessment of the suitability of their arrangements is comprehensive, resulting in effective support for both the child and their carer. The known numbers of private fostering arrangements are low, but leaders are appropriately focused on raising the awareness of these arrangements.

15. Children who are young carers are appropriately identified. A commissioned service provides effective help and support which is valued by children and their families.
16. Children who are at risk of coming into care are supported without delay by a range of skilled multidisciplinary professionals.
17. When children go missing from home or care, or are at risk of exploitation, purposeful interventions are coordinated effectively by workers who carefully consider the complex factors that may impact on the success of such interventions. As a result, children are helped effectively to keep safe with risks reduced.
18. The oversight of children who are electively home educated is well organised and effective. Children's circumstances are understood well, and partners collaborate to ensure that children's needs and safety are considered and prioritised.
19. The numbers of children missing education have reduced. This is due to a multi-agency approach to understanding the barriers to attendance. As a result, children are supported to successfully obtain and maintain school places.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

20. Children enter care at the right time and when it is in their best interests. Decisions to place children with their brothers and sisters are informed by assessments to consider their individual needs. Every effort is made to keep children living with their families, with the wider family explored early on through family network meetings.
21. Most kinship carers are approved in a timely way, although decision-making and delays have affected a small number of children, particularly those placed by the local authority in agreement with parents, without the oversight of the court. For these children, while they are living with carers who meet their needs, decisive action has not been taken to approve the arrangement or consider appropriate alternatives. As a result, children and their carers have not received the support they needed. Leaders have plans in place to prevent recurrence and improve the support available.
22. If it is not possible for children to remain living with their families, children live in homes where they thrive and where their needs are met, whether these are local or out of area. There is careful consideration given to children's cultural needs and carers are identified in line with children's wishes about the homes they wish to live in. Carers actively promote and are involved in family time, which helps children to see important people in their lives working together to meet their needs.
23. Children's care plans outline all possible outcomes and steps are taken to plan for potential reunification with parents or for permanence within or outside the

family. When reunification is a viable option, purposeful direct work and clear risk assessments help parents understand children's needs and workers' expectations. Children benefit from thorough assessments which inform well-planned transitions to support safe and successful reunification. Where this is not possible, effective oversight from independent reviewing officers (IROs) and managers ensures that most children's plans swiftly progress so they can feel safe and secure in their homes.

24. Some children have experienced a delay in having their placement formally approved as their long-term home. This has meant they have not had the assurance they need in a timely way. Leaders have recently taken steps to address this, and this is beginning to improve timeliness in permanence decisions.
25. The needs of disabled children in care are understood and met. Families receive increasing support before care is considered, and transitions into care are well planned with the involvement of parents. Transition planning with adult services is clear, effective and timely for children within the disabilities service.
26. Children benefit from attending schools that support their needs well. Their needs are understood by a range of professionals working with the child who work well together to remove barriers to learning. While personal education plans (PEPs) require further development, discussions held with children and their carers about what support will help are well reflected in children's care plans, with the virtual school team integral to this support. Considerable effort is taken to re-engage children into education, with children's emotional and social needs appropriately recognised in their plans and support in place through strong multi-agency relationships. Children have access to a wide range of activities with their carers and their peers.
27. Children's health needs are prioritised and understood from regular, up-to-date health assessments. Children benefit from support from universal and specialist services when this is required.
28. Children benefit from long-standing relationships with their social workers. Visits to children often exceed statutory requirements and respond to children's needs and wishes. Life-story work begins early to help children understand their experiences and journey through care. This is carefully planned, sensitively delivered and informed by children's views and wishes. This results in children having a say in their lives and understanding some of the complexities that exist in their families.
29. There are a small number of children living in unregistered children's homes whose care is therefore not regulated. All children have high levels of support, and their circumstances are subject to regular review which is overseen by senior leaders. Action has been taken by leaders and commissioners, and as a result, these homes are in the process of registration. Risk assessments include

increased social work and quality assurance visits. Leaders have an accurate understanding of the complex needs of these children.

30. A small number of children with complex needs experience repeat placement moves. For these children, planning has not always been sufficiently robust to prevent further disruption, and there is limited evidence of sufficient challenge to carers who give immediate notice with no time to plan effectively and help the child to move on.
31. For unaccompanied asylum-seeking children arriving in Luton, careful consideration is given to finding accommodation that meets their diverse needs. Although cultural matches are not always possible, carers support children's cultural and religious identity. While social workers invest time in understanding each child's background and heritage, children's care plans do not always state how their cultural needs will be met. Children are well supported to have their immigration needs addressed promptly. Education, including English language support, is accessed quickly, helping many children to make good progress.
32. Children who are involved in the 'All In It Together' group value the opportunity to participate in activities and corporate parenting work. They say they feel listened to, respected and influential as a voice for children in care. The group provides a positive, inclusive environment where children feel safe.
33. The fostering service has experienced disruption following changes to management and the panel arrangements, affecting permanence timeliness for children and support for some carers. Leaders and managers are now embedding improvements to strengthen practice.
34. The adoption service is managing pressures linked to team capacity, which has limited the work it can complete. Strong support from the adoption alliance has helped minimise the impact of this on children. Notwithstanding these pressures, experienced practitioners contribute to effective matching, and children benefit from considerations for early permanence, thoughtful transitions, regular visits and tailored support to maintain stability for children in their homes.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: requires improvement to be good

35. Care leavers mostly benefit from relationships with personal advisers (PAs) who demonstrate care, compassion and sensitive practice. However, not all care leavers are allocated a PA before they leave care. For those that are, the involvement of their PA varies, with introductions often taking place close to when they leave care. This is due to capacity issues in the leaving care service. To mitigate the impact of this, some social workers continue working with children when they exit care. While this maintains continuity, this prevents care leavers from building a relationship with the worker who will continue to support them into early adulthood.

36. PAs' caseloads have reduced, but most remain relatively high. Not all PAs provide consistent, individualised, relationship-based support to care leavers. There are examples of strong practice where PAs demonstrate persistence, flexibility and effective advocacy. In these cases, care leavers are more likely to remain engaged and feel supported. However, this is not consistent across the service; visiting expectations are not always met, and sometimes PAs meet care leavers in office settings rather than in their accommodation. In less strong practice, contact with care leavers is reactive and focused on immediate practical issues, rather than promoting longer-term stability and independence.
37. Care leavers are involved in the formulation of their pathway plans, and their views and aspirations are included. Most are reviewed at appropriate intervals, and where management oversight is effective, shortfalls are identified and addressed. Nevertheless, the quality and impact of pathway planning is variable. Some plans are not updated promptly following significant changes, such as accommodation moves, and some plans rely heavily on signposting and lack clarity about how support will be delivered or reviewed.
38. The health needs of care leavers are understood by PAs who support them to access services and manage their health independently.
39. Care leavers in custody are supported with kindness and compassion. PAs demonstrate a strong understanding of risks, histories and strengths, and maintain regular contact with care leavers and their families. Effective multi-agency working supports early release planning so that care leavers can manage this transition well and reintegrate back into their communities.
40. Disabled care leavers are mostly supported well. However, the transitions into adulthood can depend on the expertise of the social worker involved.
41. When there are concerns about possible risks or exploitation for care leavers, this is recognised and responded to. In stronger practice examples, PAs are persistent and multi-agency responses are effective, although care leavers' records do not always clearly evidence the impact of this work. When care leavers are parents or parents-to-be, any risks are appropriately highlighted, and they are supported well to understand these concerns. PAs work with allocated social workers and a multi-agency team to help care leavers to be the best parents they can be and support them to understand the decisions made. Additional practical and financial support is available in the care leaver offer for parents, with more support sessions planned in the future to be delivered from the care leavers hub.
42. The local offer for care leavers is accessible, clearly set out and included in care leavers' pathway plans. In stronger practice, PAs actively explore entitlements and support care leavers to access financial and practical help, but this is not always seen in their records. Care leavers told inspectors they were not always clear about their entitlements but did recognise they could approach their PA if they had any questions.

43. Care leavers who were former unaccompanied asylum-seeking children receive culturally sensitive support, and particular attention is given to their emotional wellbeing. They are supported early on to ensure that decisions on their immigration status are made. This provides some security and enables care leavers to invest in opportunities for their future. PAs also support care leavers to reconnect with family members abroad and to develop local community networks.
44. Care leavers receive effective support to access education, employment and training. The virtual school plays an instrumental role in this offer, with many care leavers offered mentors with whom they have positive relationships, to help them navigate new experiences. This has successfully led to increased numbers of care leavers in education, employment or training.
45. The accommodation available for care leavers is much improved. There is an effective multi-agency approach to a complexity of housing needs. Proactive advocacy, which includes a dedicated housing solutions officer and clear escalation routes, prevents homelessness and supports stability. Care leavers are supported to develop independent living skills, including budgeting and tenancy readiness, which helps to sustain their tenancies. 'Staying put' arrangements are also used as an option for some young people, enabling a continuity of care.
46. Care leavers continue to receive support beyond the age of 21 where risks or vulnerabilities remain. Those who are in higher education or those who have complex needs also benefit from sustained and effective support. For care leavers who are progressing well, support defaults to a 'keeping in touch' arrangement. Contact is then made with them by former care leavers working in the service who are passionate and determined to ensure care leavers understand their ongoing entitlements. Sometimes it is not clear to see from care leavers' records that the keeping in touch arrangement is a choice offered to care leavers, although this is now the expectation, with a clear opt-out approach.
47. A care leavers hub has been created to enable care leavers to have their own space. This is a temporary location, with an alternative venue being explored. Plans are in place to deliver workshops and sessions from the hub; however, this is in its early stages. The care leavers council is an active group, determined to improve the experiences of care leavers. It has autonomy and the support of leaders to develop the service further.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

48. A strong, visible and inclusive leadership team, supported by political and corporate colleagues, has improved services for children and care leavers. Luton was selected to be a pathfinder under Wave 2 of the FFC Pathfinder Programme. Leaders have redesigned services and implemented the family help

service, multi-agency teams and created LCPPs in addition to improvements across other services. These services have enabled families to benefit from timely support which meets their individual and collective needs and for children in care to develop and achieve. Leaders have maintained a continuous focus on children and care leavers and have been clear on the improvements needed. This has been supported by a coherent improvement plan embraced by leaders at all levels and across the council. Leaders have communicated their expectations effectively and have nurtured skill development, driving practice improvements.

49. The chief executive and lead member prioritise and are actively engaged in the improvement of children's services and have ensured, despite significant budget pressures, that the service is financially viable and able to deliver sustainable changes. They oversee and challenge appropriately when needed but demonstrate confidence in the leadership team to deliver the improvements.
50. The director of children's services, who was appointed after the last inspection, has created stability, with a permanent management team in place to drive the necessary changes. Leaders have worked collaboratively with support from the corporate centre and with managers at all tiers to ensure that wholesale changes, such as the implementation of family help, are successful.
51. Leaders are effective corporate parents and understand what children need. The corporate parenting board has been refreshed with a strategic plan that has been co-produced with children, care leavers and partners. The emphasis is on 'less corporate, more parent' to demonstrate love, flexibility and compassion. The implementation and oversight of the strategic plan enable leaders and elected members to measure success. The views of children are sought, and leaders ensure these views are responded to. Children and care leavers are now integral to the refreshed corporate parenting board, with a care leavers project board in place, chaired by the lead member and with support from care leavers to oversee improvements required.
52. Luton's participation strategy has been effective in ensuring that the voice of children in care and care leavers informs the development of services. The 'All In It Together' group has regular contact with the lead member and senior leaders and they experience meaningful engagement. The care leavers council has influenced, developed and helped to improve services. While there is more to do, there is a great deal of enthusiasm and determination from leaders and those care leavers involved to improve the experience of care leavers.
53. Strategic partnerships are strong and mature. The Safeguarding Partnership Board provides strategic oversight and has effective governance arrangements to ensure that statutory partners meet the needs of children and their families, with children's safety paramount. The partnership is committed to the delivery of the social care reforms. This commitment is reflected in the presence of key partners in the multi-agency teams.

54. There is a shortage of local homes for children, and as a result, leaders rely on independent providers that are located further away. The sufficiency strategy, informed by clear needs analysis, outlines a clear short-, medium- and long-term delivery plan to increase placement options.
55. The quality assurance framework is comprehensive and robust, and allows leaders to have a line of sight into the quality of practice and children's experiences. This is used to improve services as individual and wider organisational learning needs are captured, which then informs training. There is considerable emphasis on 'completing the loop' to ensure that changes are made. This is also evidenced in multi-agency audits, ensuring that this commitment to improving practice is far reaching across partner agencies.
56. As a result of this effective quality assurance programme, improvements have been made and leaders are aware of the strengths and the challenges that remain. Some developments needed, such as support and approval for kinship carers and some delays in ratifying placements, had only been identified recently but leaders have responded quickly and have a plan in place to address these issues.
57. Management oversight at all tiers is reflected in children's records. Supervision records mostly demonstrate reflective discussions and a thorough understanding of children's circumstances which has mostly positively impacted care planning. Where this has not been evidenced, leaders have acted to remedy this.
58. The workforce and the senior leadership team are representative of the diverse community they serve. This is a significant strength in Luton, with workers telling us that they are proud of this, and inspectors have seen evidence of how this has made a difference to children and their families. The diverse leadership team provides positive role models to frontline staff and enables the workforce to positively consider career development in Luton.
59. Having a stable workforce has been, and continues to be a priority for leaders. There is an understandable emphasis on recruiting a permanent staff group to provide consistency for families. The numbers of agency staff have reduced, with several workers converting to permanent posts. Their positive experience of Luton's leadership culture is supporting this trend.
60. Leaders have invested in 'grow your own' routes into social work and have used campaigns successfully to recruit social workers to the area. Effective support is provided by the academy to support and develop newly qualified workers. Positive changes in culture and inclusive practice have also enabled staff retention, resulting in a reduction in the turnover of staff. Some children had experienced changes in workers before and during the implementation of the family help service; however, this has been more consistent recently.

61. Leaders have managed large-scale organisational changes effectively. They are collaborative and have sought the views of workers both before and as changes have been made. The workforce has responded positively to this, with some workers taking an instrumental role in the development of the family help service as this was rolled out across localities. As a result, many practitioners can talk about improvement and the difference this has made for them as workers and the children and families they work with. Most have manageable caseloads and resources available, which provides significant additionality to their work. PAs have higher caseloads; however, leaders have already increased capacity to address this. Leaders continue to review this, taking a considered and systematic approach.
62. Regular training is provided for frontline staff and managers have benefited from participating in a leadership programme. All workers spoken to stated how much they enjoyed working for Luton, with many expressing their loyalty and commitment. They all said that they felt supported, equipped and safe to do their work. Senior leaders were reported to be visible and approachable, visiting children with them in practice week and creating the right environment for them to deliver relationship-based, purposeful work. Workers show care and compassion and describe love for the children they work with, and this is exemplified by leaders.

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